

Global CO₂ Emissions: Trends, Regional Shifts, and Per Capita Inequalities

A data-driven overview from 1750 to
2024

Data Sources: Global Carbon Budget
2025, NASA

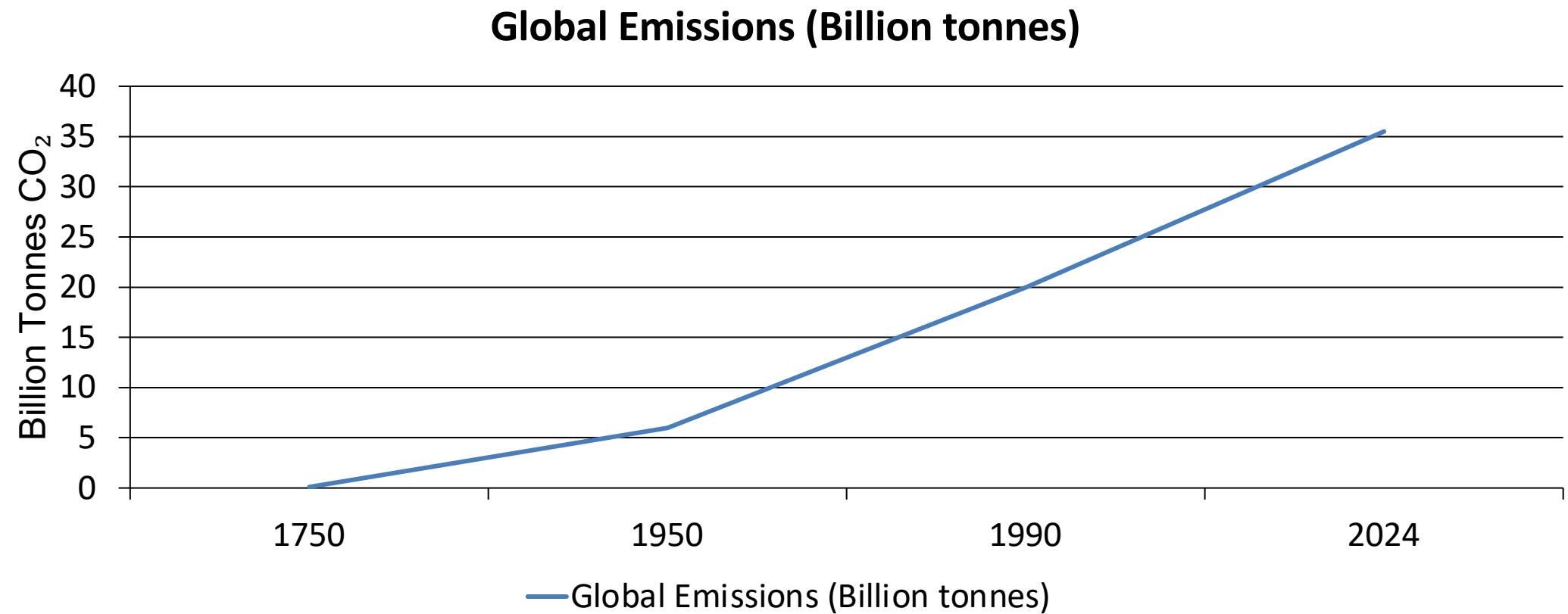
Atmospheric CO₂ Reaches 429 ppm — 50% Above Pre-Industrial Levels

Latest Measurement (Feb 2026): 429 ppm

- Pre-industrial baseline: ~280 ppm
- A more than 50% increase, accelerating sharply since 1958
- 1.5× greater than the natural increase at the end of the last ice age (which took thousands of years)

Global Fossil Fuel CO₂ Emissions Grew Six-Fold: 6 Billion to 35+ Billion Tonnes

From negligible levels in 1750, emissions hit 6 Bt in 1950, 20 Bt in 1990, and exceed 35 Bt today.

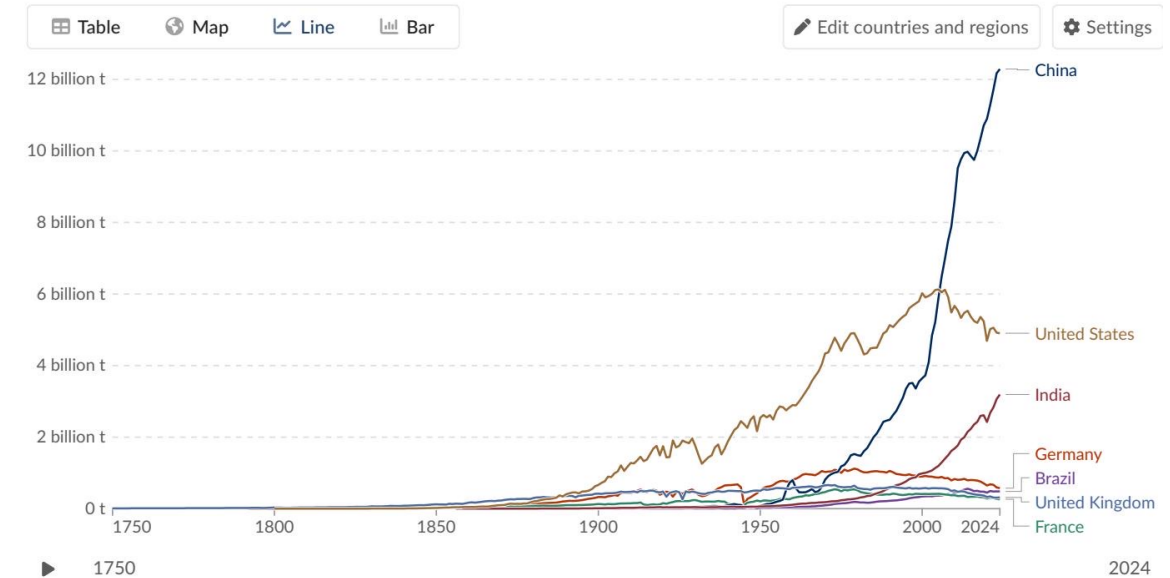


China Now Emits Over 12 Billion Tonnes — More Than Double the United States

Country / Region	Annual CO ₂ (Bt)	Share	Trend
China	~12.5	~27%	Slight increase
United States	~5.0	~14%	Declining
India	~3.0	~8%	Rising
EU-27	~2.7	~7%	Declining
Germany	~0.6	~1.7%	Declining
Brazil	~0.5	~1.4%	Stable
France / UK	~0.3 (each)	~0.8-0.9%	Declining

Annual CO₂ emissions

Carbon dioxide (CO₂) emissions from fossil fuels and industry. Land-use change emissions are not included.



Data source: Global Carbon Budget (2025) – [Learn more about this data](#)

OurWorldinData.org/co2-and-greenhouse-gas-emissions | CC BY

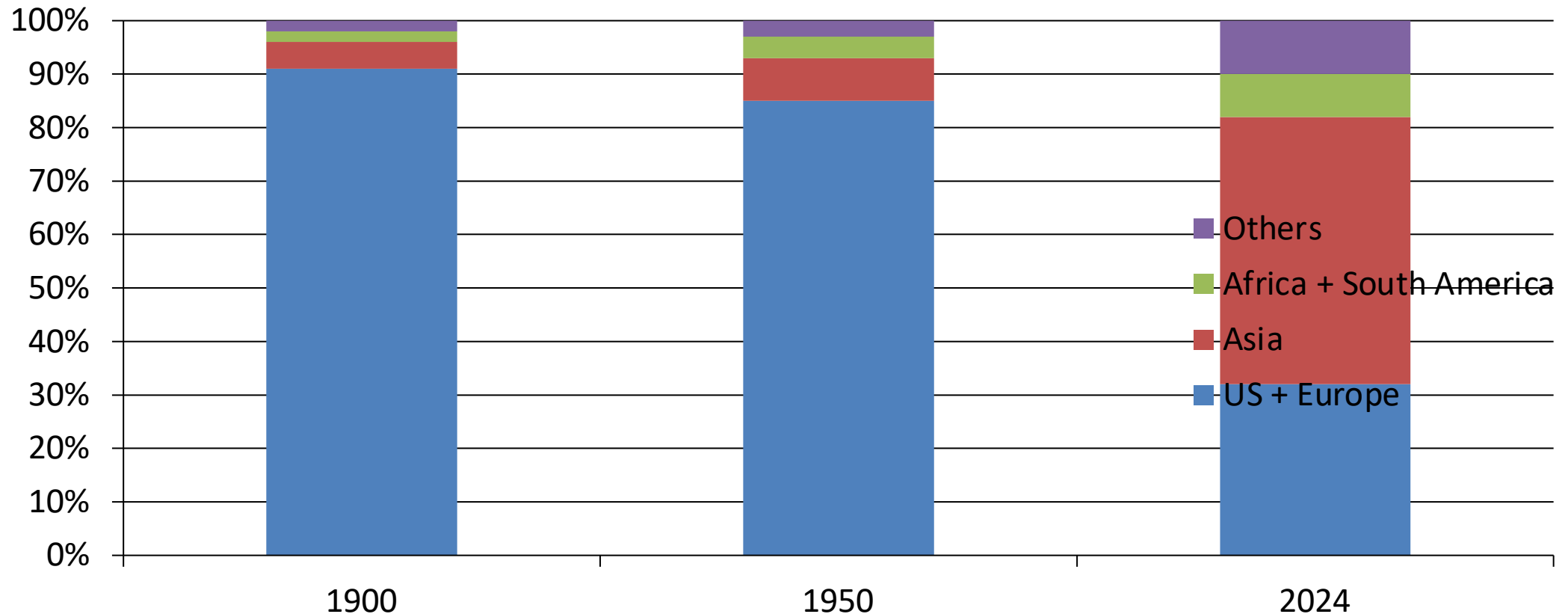
Download

Share

Enter full-screen

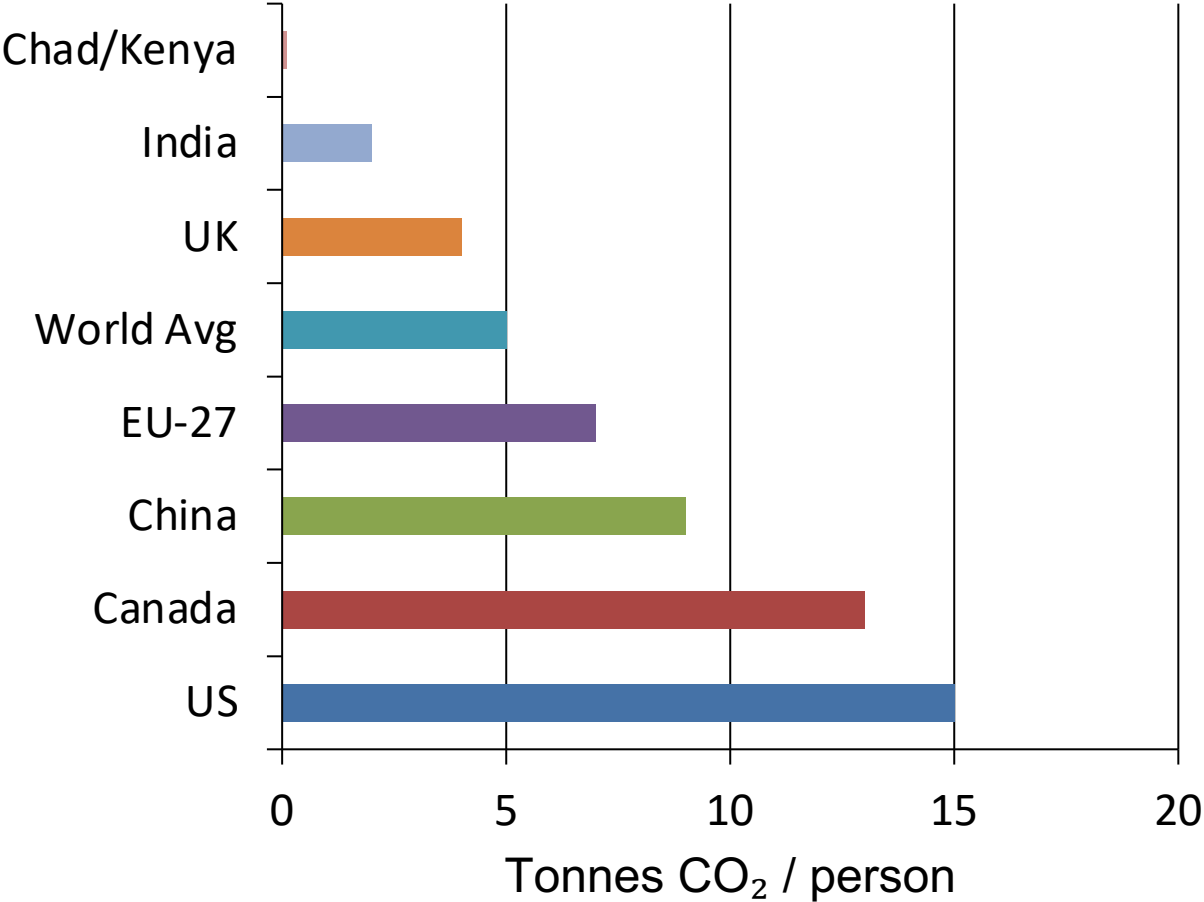
Asia Now Accounts for ~50% of Global Emissions; US + Europe Below One-Third

In 1900, Europe and the US dominated (>90%). Today, Asia leads (~50%), while Africa and South America each remain at just 3-4%.



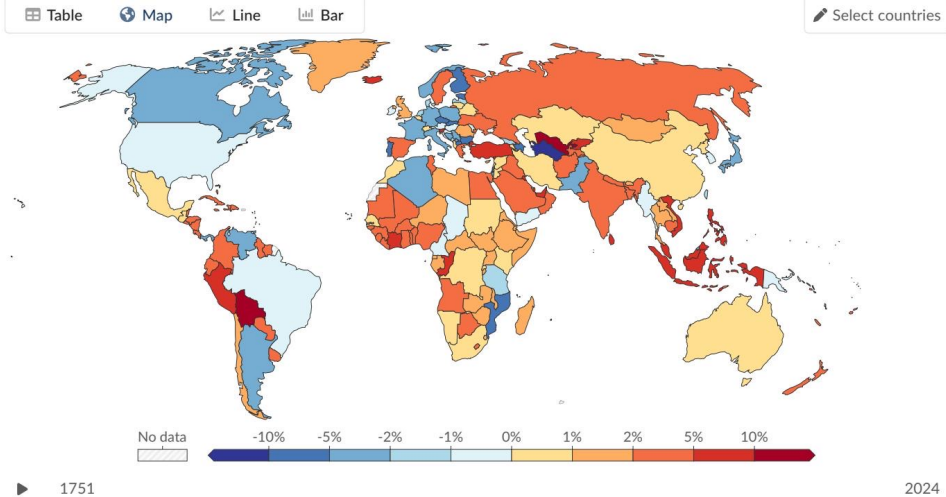
Per Capita Gap: 15 t in the US vs. 0.1 t in Chad — a 150× Disparity

Tonnes per year



Annual percentage change in CO₂ emissions, 2024

Carbon dioxide (CO₂) emissions from fossil fuels and industry. Land-use change emissions are not included.

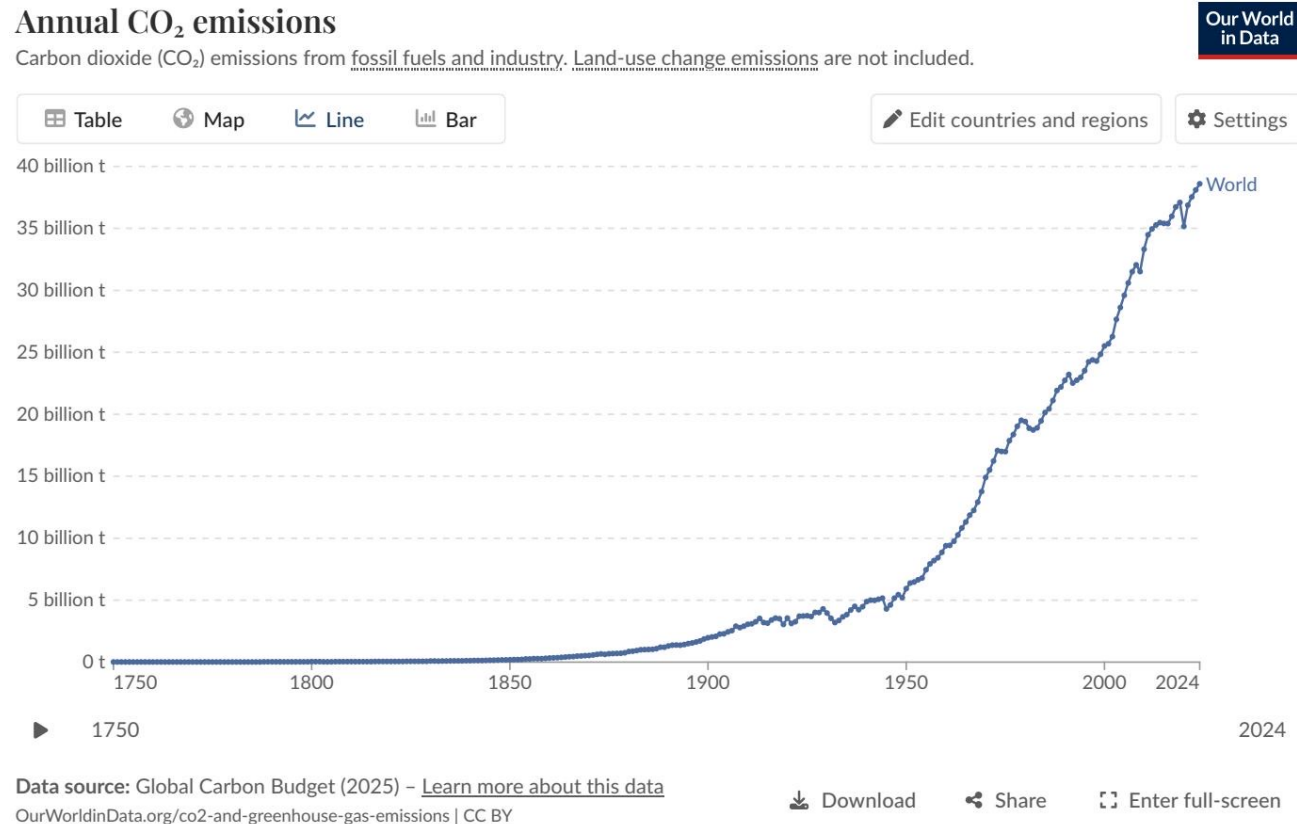


Data source: Global Carbon Budget (2025) - [Learn more about this data](#)
OurWorldinData.org/co2-and-greenhouse-gas-emissions | CC BY

Download Share Enter full-screen

2024 Snapshot: US and Europe Cut Emissions While Russia and SE Asia Increase

- US and much of Europe: Declines of roughly -1% to -5%
- Russia, SE Asia, and parts of Africa: Increases of +2% to +10% or more



Energy Mix Explains Why France Emits Far Less Per Capita Than Germany

Countries with similar living standards can differ significantly based on their energy mix. France and the UK have much lower per capita emissions than Germany or the Netherlands due to higher nuclear and renewable shares.

Region / Country	Per Capita CO ₂	Primary Energy Driver
France / UK	~4 tonnes/year	Higher nuclear & renewable shares
Germany / Netherlands	Higher (above EU avg)	Higher fossil fuel share

Key Takeaways: Emissions Are Still Rising, But the Map of Responsibility Is Shifting

- Global emissions exceed 35 Bt and have not yet peaked, despite slowing growth.
- China alone emits >25% of the global total, more than double the United States.
- Per capita inequalities remain extreme, with a 150× gap between the highest emitters and the lowest.
- The US and Europe are seeing declining emissions, though their historical cumulative responsibility remains large.
- Policy choices matter: energy mix (renewables, nuclear vs. fossil fuels) largely determines per capita outcomes among developed nations.